

Te Waonui a Tāne

Thriving Marae for Thriving Communities

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Green

When marae are strong, communities are stronger. At marae cultures thrive, partnerships grow, communities become more resilient, and local solutions are developed by the people who know their communities best.

The Green Party policy Te Waonui a Tāne will recognise and resource marae as the critical social and cultural infrastructure they are, to keep our communities connected, safe and welcomed.

Te Waonui a Tāne, the Green Party policy for thriving marae and communities, recognises that marae are not simply buildings—marae are living ecosystems of people, whenua, culture, knowledge, and communities.

For many New Zealanders, Māori and non-Māori alike, marae are part of the shared cultural landscape that shapes our national identity and contributes to what makes Aotearoa unique in the world. Marae are essential and intergenerational community partners to local councils, government agencies, schools, community and health organisations, to improve outcomes for all whānau.

Marae have also repeatedly demonstrated their importance during times of crisis. Time and again, marae have opened their doors to support entire communities at the worst of times.

Marae have played a vital role in civil defence and community responses from the Christchurch and Kaikōura earthquakes, to the severe weather events impacting Te Tai Rāwhiti, Te Tai Tokerau, Canterbury, and other regions affected by states of emergency.

Despite their importance, marae across the motu continue to face a compounding number of challenges that threaten both their operational capability and cultural integrity.

Funding programmes are often short-term, capped, and prescribed rather than community-led. Many are fragmented across multiple agencies, and difficult to access for marae without the resources to navigate complex application and reporting processes.

This makes it difficult for marae committees to undertake long-term planning, restore important infrastructure, build capability, or invest in projects that strengthen their communities for future generations.

Despite the enduring wealth and advantage the Crown has obtained through historic injustice and dispossession of Māori, the Treaty Settlement process makes the Crown the wrongdoer, the negotiator, and the rule maker.

The Crown continues to set the terms of negotiations – deciding which resources may be returned, which assets are available, and how much compensation iwi can receive. This does not reflect natural justice or a partner acting in good faith.

Many marae are managing ageing buildings and failing infrastructure, financial constraints, limited opportunities to generate sustainable income, and declining numbers of ahikā to uphold tikanga and care for marae.

By restoring and sustaining marae, we strengthen the foundations that allow communities to thrive.

Together, we can ensure future generations inherit a vibrant, resilient, and self-determining community and Aotearoa.

Marae should have the support to plan for generations, not election cycles. Te Waonui a Tāne creates a permanent solution to access funding for short-term and long-term needs, while building local capability, and providing outcomes that benefit everyone in Aotearoa.

The Green Party will establish Te Rangatiratanga Trust with an initial funding commitment that will be transferred into the ownership of hapū and iwi of Aotearoa to create the capital base for the permanent trust.

Te Rangatiratanga Trust will restore and sustain marae as the living heart of our communities by creating a permanent, independent source of funding for the full marae ecosystem—the people, whenua, buildings, culture, and relationships that keep marae and their surrounding communities thriving.

Closer partnerships, better outcomes

Many community services in rural and regional areas such as education, housing support, food security, health and youth programmes operate in isolation from one another.

Funding contracts are often short-term, fragmented, and tied to different agencies with separate reporting requirements. This makes it difficult for marae, councils, and community organisations to work together in a coordinated way, even when they are serving the same whānau.

How Te Waonui a Tāne responds: Flexible funding through Te Rangatiratanga Trust would support marae-led, cross-sector community initiatives that bring together local councils, service providers, schools and social service organisations. Regional commissioning bodies would help reduce administrative burden, align funding requirements and support shared planning, delivery, and evaluation. The long-term feature of Te Tōtara Haemata ensures successful partnerships can continue and scale over time.

The outcome: Marae become reliable partners for coordinated community action, where services work together rather than in isolation. Whānau experience more seamless support across health, education, and social needs, while local organisations achieve better outcomes through shared resources and reduced duplication.

Importantly, Māori-led approaches strengthen outcomes for the whole community, not only Māori. When services are designed around holistic wellbeing, non-Māori also benefit from more accessible healthcare, stronger emergency preparedness, improved social support, and better connection to local services. This creates more resilient, cohesive communities where improved wellbeing is shared across everyone living in the area.

Marae resilience for safer communities

During and after times of crisis such as climate charged weather events, marae have repeatedly demonstrated their importance for keeping people safe, connected, and cared for. Time and again, marae have opened their doors to welcome and support entire communities.

But one in three marae are at risk of flooding, one in three are situated in landslide-prone areas, one in five are in tsunami evacuation zones and two in five are susceptible to liquefaction in the event of an earthquake. At the same time, marae are increasingly relied upon as emergency response hubs, despite often lacking resilient power, water supplies and emergency infrastructure.

How Te Waonui a Tāne responds: Te Rākau Whakarauora Restoration Fund would provide immediate funding for projects such as solar power and battery storage, emergency water supplies, communication systems, and secure storage for emergency equipment. It could also support climate adaptation initiatives including flood mitigation, erosion control, vulnerable infrastructure relocation, improving stormwater management, and other projects that strengthen the long-term resilience of marae and surrounding whenua. Regional commissioning bodies would assist with planning, technical advice, and project delivery, while Te Tōtara Haemata would provide an ongoing source of funding to maintain and enhance resilience options over time.

The outcome: Marae are better prepared to withstand the impacts of climate change and natural disasters while continuing to provide shelter, food, coordination and support when communities need them most. Investing in resilience before disasters occur helps reduce future costs, protects places of cultural significance, and strengthens the safety and wellbeing of the wider community.

Rural health hubs for local wellbeing

Many rural communities face long travel times, limited transport options, and limited access to healthcare. Marae have become trusted locations for delivering drive-through, pop-up, and mobile health services during times of need, yet many lack the facilities needed to provide regular, preventative healthcare.

As a result, many people delay seeking treatment until their health needs become more serious and require hospital care.

How Te Waonui a Tāne responds: Funding from Te Rākau Whakarauora or Te Tōtara Haemata would support marae to establish or upgrade spaces where they can host regular primary healthcare services, including GP clinics, nurses' services, mental health support, screening programmes, midwives, immunisation clinics, and kaupapa Māori health providers. Regional commissioning bodies would support marae to coordinate with healthcare providers and deliver these projects.

The outcome: Whānau can access preventative healthcare closer to home, helping to identify and address health concerns before they develop into more serious conditions. This strengthens the health and wellbeing of communities, reduces pressure on the healthcare system, and supports marae in continuing to serve as trusted, locally led centres that support healthier futures for all of us.



The Green Party will:

- **Uphold tino rangatiratanga and self-governance**
- Facilitate nationwide wānanga to establish the trustee body, two funds, and governance mechanisms.
- Create Te Rangatiratanga Trust, owned and governed by hapū and iwi of Aotearoa.
- **Establish Te Rangatiratanga Trust**
- Dedicated Crown funding of $2.44 billion total for Rangatiratanga Trust.
- The Trust will govern immediate investment and long-term sustainability via two complementary funds.
- **Build a restoration fund that provides for urgent and immediate needs**
- Implement Te Rākau Whakarauora Restoration Fund for immediate and urgent priorities.
- Allocate $400 million for immediate and urgent projects over four years.
- **Build an intergenerational fund that provides for generations to come**
- Implement Te Tōtara Haemata Intergenerational Fund for long term investment in marae and community development.
- Invest $2 billion in a diversified portfolio to generate returns for annual distribution.
- Preserve the investment fund's capital for the benefit of future generations.

Tino rangatiratanga and self-governance

Before the Trust is established, the Green Party will work with key groups to outline and timeline the move from aspiration to reality. We will facilitate nationwide wānanga informed by constitutional transformation processes, such as Matike Mai, to support collectively designing the Trust's governance structure. The outcome of this process will become the foundation of the Trust Deed.

This process will facilitate hapū and iwi to determine:

- How collective ownership is exercised
- How trustees are appointed and removed
- Regional representation
- Tikanga alignment
- Dispute resolution process
- Succession arrangements

The governance model can draw from successful Māori-led arrangements already operating across Aotearoa, including Whānau Ora commissioning approaches, hapū and iwi governance structures, and Māori-owned organisations that manage significant resources while remaining accountable to their communities and tikanga.

Once established, Te Rangatiratanga Trust will operate independently through governance arrangements designed to protect its intergenerational purpose, maintain transparency, and ensure accountability to marae, hapū, iwi, communities, and the public.

The role of the Crown will be limited to establishing the Trust, supporting the collective design process, and transferring the agreed capital contribution to establish the Trust.

The Crown will have no authority to direct investments, appoint trustees, alter funding decisions, or interfere with the operation of the Trust beyond ordinary law applying equally to all trusts.

Te Rangatiratanga Trust

Te Rangatiratanga Trust will govern a permanent source of funding for marae, hapū, and the communities they serve.

A $2.44 billion Crown funding input will establish the Trust and its two complementary funds:

Te Rākau Whakarauora Restoration Fund, which provides for urgent and priority needs, and Te Tōtara Haemata Intergenerational Fund, which protects and grows capital for future generations.

Together, these funds will provide immediate and long-term support for the marae ecosystem, remedy inequities derived from historic and ongoing Crown actions, enhance marae capability and community partnerships, and create intergenerational wellbeing independent of political cycles.

Te Rangatiratanga Trust is designed as a permanent capital base for a funding model that provides both immediate support for marae and long-term funding certainty for future generations. Instead of relying on short-term funding cycles, the Trust creates a permanent source of funding that grows over time and supports marae, hapū, and communities to lead their own aspirations.

The Trust combines immediate restoration investment with an intergenerational investment fund that protects and grows wealth for the future.

Unlike traditional government funding programmes, decisions about how funding is invested and distributed will be made independently of Ministers and successive governments. This provides certainty for marae and communities while ensuring investment decisions remain focused on long-term aspirations rather than changing political priorities.

Te Rangatiratanga Trust is separate from the Treaty settlement framework. It does not replace, affect, or extinguish any existing rights or obligations under Te Tiriti o Waitangi. Rather than providing Treaty settlement redress, the Trust establishes a forward-looking investment mechanism that supports the long-term resilience and prosperity of marae and the communities they serve.

Te Rākau Whakarauora Restoration Fund

Intergenerational funds take time to mature, but many marae and communities require investment now.

Te Rākau Whakarauora Restoration Trust is a time-limited establishment fund that provides immediate investment in marae resilience and restoration while Te Tōtara Haemata Intergenerational Fund is established. It will address urgent priorities such as restoring buildings and infrastructure, strengthening capability, improving climate resilience, and supporting projects that support marae and their surrounding communities to thrive.

Funding can support projects such as:

- Restoring marae buildings, fixtures, and infrastructure.
- Strengthening emergency preparedness and response capability.
- Improving climate resilience and adaptation.
- Supporting capability development and project delivery.
- Protecting taonga, wāhi tapu, and cultural heritage.
- Enabling marae-led partnerships that improve community wellbeing.

Te Rākau Whakarauora will also provide an opportunity to establish and refine the Trust's funding pathways, ensuring future investment through Te Tōtara Haemata is effective, accessible, and responsive to community aspirations.

Te Tōtara Haemata Intergenerational Fund

At the heart of Te Waonui a Tāne is Te Tōtara Haemata Intergenerational Fund, a permanent intergenerational fund designed to preserve and grow the Trust's capital through long-term investment.

Rather than spending the capital itself, investment returns will be distributed to support the aspirations of hapū and iwi of Aotearoa, while protecting the capital for future generations. This creates an enduring source of funding that grows over time and provides long-term certainty independent of political cycles.

Through responsible investment, Te Tōtara Haemata will create enduring intergenerational prosperity and strengthen Māori economic capacity while aligning with environmental sustainability, social wellbeing, and the long-term success of future generations.

Investment opportunities may include:

- Renewable energy and climate transition
- Investment in whenua Māori
- Housing and regional development
- Māori enterprise and business growth
- Emerging industries and technologies

Decisions made closer to communities

The Green Party recognises that marae, hapū, and local communities are best placed to determine their own priorities and define what success looks like.

Funding distribution can follow a similar approach to Whānau Ora models, using regional commissioning bodies to ensure decisions remain close to communities.

This approach reduces barriers to accessing funding, supports smaller marae that may have limited administrative capacity, and allows communities to determine their own priorities.

Funding criteria can also be broadened to support a wide range of aspirations that are usually not accounted for when determined by Government, including:

Te Pūtake – Acknowledging the Past: Supporting projects that recognise whakapapa, protect cultural heritage, and acknowledge the achievements and contributions of tūpuna.

Te Puāwai – Acting Today and Investing in Tomorrow: Supporting the holistic revitalisation of marae and the aspirations of hapori Māori, hapū, and iwi.

Te Poipoi – Community Partnership Projects: Supporting marae to partner with wider communities, councils, and organisations on projects that benefit the rohe.

Accountability can be maintained through transparent reporting and whānau-centred outcome measures developed with communities. Instead of quantitative reporting, success can be measured through outcomes including:

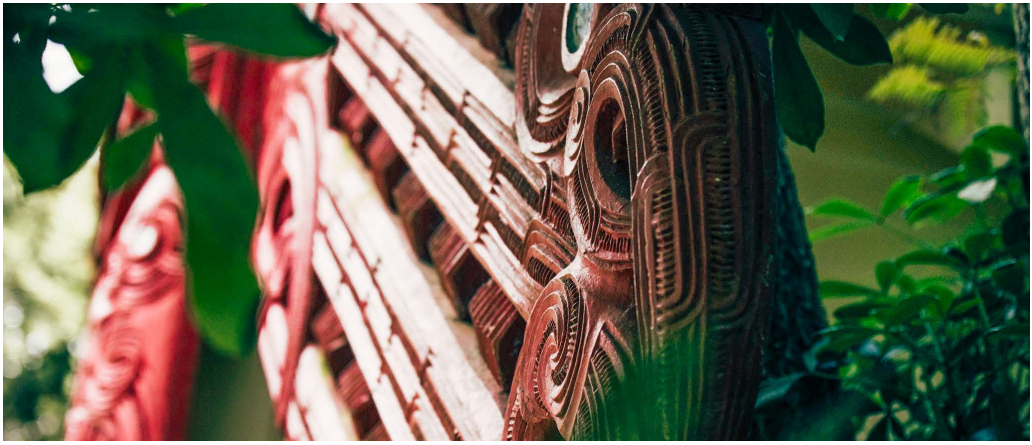
Cultural wellbeing – strengthening whakapapa, tikanga, mātauranga Māori, and identity.

Social wellbeing – supporting whānau resilience, connection, and community strength.

Commercial activity – employment and training opportunities, tourism levels, cost of living.

Environmental resilience – protecting whenua and supporting kaitiakitanga.

Long-term wellbeing – number of generations that have benefitted from the funding.



Funding the future

The Green Party proposes an initial Crown funding commitment of $2.44 billion with any further Crown contributions to be determined during the negotiation process. This amount is aligned with other comparable long-term public funds, including the New Zealand Superannuation Fund's initial $2.4 billion contribution in 2003 and the Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Land and Sea Future Fund's $2 billion contribution in 2019 in Australia.

The $2.44 billion investment is intended for the establishment and maintenance of the Trust's components including Te Rākau Whakarauora Restoration Fund and the seed funding for Te Tōtara Haemata Intergenerational Fund for at least 4 years until it has matured enough to access returns.

The funding is allocated in the first two years from the Crown, and the Trust will determine the investment and expenditure based on its priorities. We have modelled that the Trust will for the first four years spend $10 million a year on establishment and associated costs, $100 million a year on Te Rākau Whakarauora Restoration Funding, and invest $2 billion in seed funding for Te Tōtara Haemata.

Using the Treasury investment return assumptions in the 2026 Budget Economic and Fiscal Update we can also estimate:

- The $2 billion invested through Te Tōtara Haemata to grow to approximately $3.8 billion by 2039/40 before distributions.
- Annual distributions could provide between $47 million and $118 million in ongoing support once the fund has initially matured, while maintaining the long-term capital base.

Crown spending ($million opex)	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3	Year 4	Total
Te Rangatiratanga Trust Funding	1,220	1,220	-	-	2,440

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